

The Forest in the World's Wisdom

A Comparative Analysis of Spiritual Systems and Worldviews

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Grounding document of the Carpathian OER Commons, published as a working draft and open to co-creation. It speaks from conviction. Its facts were checked against published sources on 2026-09-27, and three readers stress-tested it the same day; the last section before the release record says what they found and what changed. That traditions share a shape says something about people; it is not evidence that a method works (foundations paper, Section 6). Points of Hutsul practice are marked [for the elders].

This survey is background reading for adults. No practice of another people described here is done with children. The school teaches no religion; children pray only with their own family or parish, as the family chooses, and every family may see anything the school does.

v0.7, 2026-09-27: source-checked and stress-tested — corrections throughout; the valley's churches placed after the taproot; the peoples of the Urals and Siberia named by their own lands; "proof" and "evidence" replaced by company.

Companion document to "The Eco-Spiritual Philosophy of the Living Forest." It surveys spiritual systems and worldviews that the Forest School learns from. The rule of the survey is stated at its end and governs throughout: the school honours these traditions by parallel, never by imitation; the local tradition leads; nothing is transplanted, and every source is named.

I. The Taproot — The Hutsul and Ukrainian Folk Worldview

The philosophy of the Living Forest grows from this ground. The Hutsul highlands treat the land as something to live with and respect: mountains, springs, and trees as presences, the high pasture a lived-with world, never a wilderness apart. Hutsul night vigils once held games, jokes, and songs beside the dead, so that no one kept the night alone. Around it lies the Ukrainian folk year, kept for centuries within the life of the Church: the Green Feasts, when homes and churches fill with branches, the Kupala fires and water customs, songs that bless the field and the year. What the school draws, and how, is for the elders of the valley to say. [for the elders]

II. The Churches of This Valley

The Orthodox and Greek-Catholic churches that hold the Carpathians carry a deep theology of creation: the world as icon of its maker, blessed with water and branch through the year's feasts; the hesychast practice of stillness and watchfulness of heart; in the Orthodox world, the Ecumenical Patriarch Bartholomew's long teaching on care for creation; and in the wider church, from Francis of Assisi, who called the creatures brother and sister, to the encyclical *Laudato Si'* on care for our common home, a green thread running through the church's history. What the school draws: the families' own feasts — the

Theophany water-blessing, the Green Feasts, the harvest — keep their place in the school's year; children keep their Sundays with their families; the parish priest is welcome at any time. The school stands beside the faith of the families it serves, never against it and never in its place.

III. The Old Ways of Northern and Eastern Europe

Before the survey crosses the oceans, it crosses the Baltic, where the old European bond to place lies close to the surface and survived long in the open.

The Baltic peoples — Lithuania, Latvia, and the old Prussian coast. Lithuania was the last state in medieval Europe to accept Christianity: it was baptised in 1387, Samogitia only in 1413, and the old ways never fully left. Sacred groves and holy oaks stood at the heart of worship — the oak as the thunder-god's tree, felled only at peril — and the world was sung: the dainas, the vast body of Latvian folk quatrains, over two hundred thousand collected, with the Lithuanian dainos their close kin, hold the sun, the seasons, the field-work, and the soul's passages, a whole cosmology kept alive in song. In living memory the singing held: the Singing Revolution of 1987 to 1991 met an empire with massed song and, largely without violence, won back independence. What the school draws: company for its own practice — that a people's bond to land can be *kept in song* across centuries of pressure, and that singing together can be survival and resistance. The valley's own singing and the dainas sound, to this school, like kin.

The Finnic north — Finland, Karelia, Estonia. In the Kalevala songs, the sage does not fight the world into shape; he *sings* it, and power over a thing comes from knowing and singing its origin. The Estonian hiis, sacred groves, are tended to this day, and the old reverence for the bear honoured even its skull, set in a tree. The bond lives on as everyman's right — the freedom of every person to walk, gather, and be at home in the land, paired with the duty to leave it unharmed — written into Estonian and Swedish law, and in Finland a custom the law upholds. What the school draws: that to know a being's origin is to be in relationship with it — every pattern card asking "what is this, and where does it come from" walks the singer's path — and that belonging to land can be both right and care.

The Norse world. The cosmos was a tree: Yggdrasil, its roots reaching to the wells of fate and wisdom and down into the cold deep, its branches spread over heaven and earth. The land was alive with landvættir, the land spirits: ships approaching home shores took down their dragon-head prows so as not to frighten them — arrival made gentle before the spirits of place. Law was spoken under the open sky, the assembly gathered outdoors on the land it governed. And wisdom, in the deepest Norse story, was won on the tree. What the school draws: the tree as a readable cosmos, which the school's children learn to read in their own way, as roots, trunk, and canopy; the practice of arriving gently on any land; and the circle under open sky as an old form of assembly. One Norse path the school honours and does not walk: the solitary vigil and the ordeal on the tree belong to that tradition's adults and stay there.

The Celts. The grove — nemeton — was a sanctuary; wells and springs were doorways of the holy; the year turned on threshold festivals, Samhain and Bealtaine. Roman writers say the learned orders trained for as much as twenty years, carrying wisdom wholly in memory and verse, and one places their teaching in caves and remote groves. In ogham, several letters bear trees' names, and medieval Irish scholars read the whole alphabet as trees, so that to learn one's letters was to learn the forest. Early Irish law ranked the trees in classes and fined their wounding — nobles of the wood, protected by statute. What the school draws: an old European precedent for teaching in and through the forest — a curriculum read in trees, thresholds kept with ceremony, and the law standing guard over the wood.

IV. The Peoples of the Urals, Taiga, Tundra, and Steppe

East of the old European ways, across the Urals and into the taiga and tundra, live peoples in their own lands: Mari El on the middle Volga; Udmurtia and Komi west of the Urals; Bashkortostan in their south; the Khanty-Mansi lands on the Ob; the Nenets tundra of Yamal; the Evenki taiga; Sakha (Yakutia); Altai, Tuva, and Buryatia. These are the traditions of peoples, never of an empire. Their languages and religions were suppressed under the empire and in the Soviet decades. The school speaks of their traditions only as they have been shared in the open, and does not speak for them or for their politics.

The Mari. In Mari El, Mari communities gather in several hundred kūsoto, sacred groves, for prayers led by priests called karts — a faith suppressed in Soviet times and practised openly today, one of Europe's last grove-faiths kept in the open. What the school draws: the knowledge that a grove-faith is still practised in the open in this decade — the hiis and the nemeton not only as memory but as neighbour.

The Udmurt. In Udmurtia, families kept kuala, household shrines, and villages kept lud, sacred groves; the village religion is still kept. What the school draws: the sacred at household scale — reverence a homestead can live.

The Komi. In Komi, where one of Europe's largest remaining virgin forests stands, the forest had its own spirit, and the Perm animal-style bronzes of the Komi and Udmurt ancestors show human and animal as one figure. What the school draws: what reverence can keep.

The Bashkirs. In Bashkortostan, the epic of Ural-batyr tells of a hero who gives the water of life to the land instead of drinking it; the stones his people heaped on his grave became the Ural Mountains. Beekeeping in the hollows of wild forest trees is still kept there. What the school draws: a life given so that the land lives, and a covenant of people, tree, and bee.

The Khanty and Mansi. The Ob-Ugrian peoples of the Khanty-Mansi lands — the closest linguistic kin of the Hungarians, and more distant kin of the Finns and Estonians — hold the bear in deepest reverence. Their bear festival, held when a bear has been killed, runs through days and nights of sacred

songs, stories, and performances; it was banned in Soviet times. What the school draws: a resemblance, not a shared origin — another community answering awe and death with song, story, and play, as the valley's vigils once did.

The Nenets. On the Yamal tundra, Nenets herding families move with the reindeer: land as partner, the herd as calendar, belonging carried in movement rather than walls. What the school draws: a teaching it learns from — that belonging can be carried in movement as well as held in walls.

The Evenki. The Evenki of the central Siberian taiga gave the word "shaman" to European languages, through Russian; outsiders then carried it to many peoples whose practices it does not fit. What the school draws: nothing it practises. The school does not use the word for its own work.

The Sakha, and the peoples of Altai, Tuva, and Buryatia. In Sakha (Yakutia), the epic *Olonkho* — inscribed by UNESCO among the world's intangible heritage — sets the cosmos around Aal Luuk Mas, the great world tree, and the *ysyakh* festival at midsummer greets the sun at its height and the year's renewal. In Altai, Tuva, and Buryatia, the eternal sky is revered above sacred peaks, travellers add stones to the oboo cairns at passes, and in *khoomui* throat-singing a single voice sounds the river, the wind, and the mountain at once. What the school draws: another reading of the cosmos as a tree; small acts of reverence at the thresholds of travel; and the company of peoples whose land is held in song.

V. North America — Named Nations

No single worldview covers the hundreds of distinct nations of North America. Turtle Island is the name many nations of the northeast give the land; it is not every nation's name. The school listens to teachings those nations have chosen to share publicly, and names them by nation.

The Thanksgiving Address (Haudenosaunee). The "words before all else", *Ganonhanyonh*: at the opening and closing of gatherings, greetings and thanks are spoken to the people, the waters, the plants, the animals, the winds, the sun, moon, and stars — until the minds of those gathered are one. It is a living practice, spoken anew by each speaker. What the school draws: its Morning Circle is its own, and it knows the Address came first; the school does not recite it.

The generations to come (Haudenosaunee). Decisions weighed for the generations yet unborn — in the Great Law's words, "those whose faces are yet beneath the surface of the ground"; Haudenosaunee teachers today speak of looking seven generations ahead. What the school draws: planting trees for children not yet born, and handing a record forward, stand beside this principle, credited to the Haudenosaunee.

All My Relations (Lakota: *mitákuye oyás'íŋ*). The prayer-word that names the whole world as family: every being related, the human one relative among many. What the school draws: its refusal of "wilderness", and a circle of care in which forest, child, elder, and community belong together.

The Honourable Harvest (as taught by Robin Wall Kimmerer, Potawatomi). Kimmerer calls it nearly universal among peoples who live close to the land. Never take the first; never take more than half; ask permission; use everything taken; give a gift in return for what is given. What the school draws: its ethic for every act of gathering — seed, branch, water, even knowledge from an elder — taking with asking, using with respect, returning more than was taken.

VI. Teachings from Other Lands

Aboriginal nations of Australia — Country and songlines. Country is kin: a living relative to be cared for, not a resource. Knowledge of land is held in songlines — routes walked and sung, where the song carries the map and the law. Songlines belong to their custodians, and much of that knowledge is restricted. What the school draws: respect, not method. The pattern language is the school's own and claims no kinship with them.

Aotearoa — the Māori way. Whakapapa binds people and the natural world into one genealogy — the forest is ancestor, not property; kaitiakitanga names the duty of guardianship that flows from that kinship. In settlements negotiated by Tūhoe and by Whanganui iwi, New Zealand law recognises Te Urewera and the Whanganui River as legal persons. What the school draws: guardianship as inherited duty, named in the school's own words.

The Andes — Pachamama and ayni. The living earth-mother receives and gives; ayni, sacred reciprocity, orders human life — help given must circulate, gifts return as gifts. Sumak kawsay, the good life, means living well *with*, never at the expense of. What the school draws: ayni stands beside the toloka as kin, and places the school's economy of care in a wider family of reciprocal economies.

Sápmi — the Sámi way. Some Sámi families herd reindeer; most Sámi live by other work, and fishing and hunting came long before herding became a whole way of life. The joik does not sing *about* a person, animal, or place — it sings them present. It was long condemned by missionaries, and was banned in schools in the Sámi area as late as the 1950s. What the school draws: song as a way of holding beings and places in presence — company for the valley's own singing.

Ubuntu, and the sacred groves of West Africa. Ubuntu, from the Nguni proverb umuntu ngumuntu ngabantu: a person is a person through other persons — being itself is relational. The Yoruba sacred grove of Osun-Osogbo has been kept for centuries and, when that care failed in the 1950s, restored; it is probably the last of many that once stood outside Yoruba settlements. What the school draws: its deepest sentence — care circulating until no one is only giver or receiver — is ubuntu extended to the land, an extension that is ours, not the proverb's; and the grove shows that reverence can keep a forest for centuries, and that it has not always been enough.

VII. The Asian Ways

Shinto (Japan), and shinrin-yoku. Nature as sacred space alive with kami. Shinrin-yoku, "forest bathing", is a name given in 1982 by Japan's forestry agency to quiet time among trees; research on its effects is young. What the school draws: sensory immersion as practice — silent walks in which the child's attention rests on the trees around them — the tenet of Bathing in Life.

Daoism (China). The living flow of the world; naturalness; wu-wei, action through non-striving; water and softness as true strength. What the school draws: its manner — patient observation, adaptation to rhythm, the forest and the child each allowed to work at their own pace; the gardener's restraint as a discipline.

Buddhism. Mindfulness as bare attention; interbeing — Thich Nhat Hanh's word for the older teaching of dependent origination: nothing exists separately, the tree in the paper, the cloud in the tree; impermanence held without despair. What the school draws: the quality of attention in its observation practices, and the composting movement's deepest logic — that what passes feeds what comes, and letting go is a form of care.

The Vedic and village traditions of India. Sacred groves (devrai and their many regional names) protected as the gods' own; ahimsa, non-harm, as the first ethic; and in living memory the Chipko movement, in which villagers — at Reni in 1974, the village women led by Gaura Devi — embraced trees with their bodies to stop the axes. What the school draws: the knowledge that people who defend a forest stand in a long line of ordinary people whose care became protection.

VIII. Judaism and Islam

Judaism. Bal tashchit — the command not to destroy wantonly, rooted in the Torah's protection of fruit trees even in war (Deuteronomy 20:19–20); shmita, the sabbath of the land, a rest every seventh year; Tu B'Shvat, the new year of the trees, kept with planting since the 1890s. What the school draws: rhythm as sacred law — even the land must rest — and one of the oldest written protections of trees in war, set down some two and a half thousand years before this one.

Islam. The human as khalifa — trustee, not owner, of the earth; mizan, the balance set in creation that must not be transgressed; the teaching, in the hadith, that one who plants a tree from which any creature eats has given charity. What the school draws: stewardship as trusteeship — the land held in care for its true owner and for those to come — and the planting of a tree as an act of generosity that outlives the planter.

IX. The Modern Convergence

Biophilia and eco-spirituality. The hypothesis, named by E. O. Wilson in 1984, that humans carry an innate need for connection with living systems; and the growing practice of spirituality expressed through care rather than dogma. What the school draws: its plainest statement — hands in the soil — speakable in the language of research as well as of reverence.

Deep ecology. The philosophical position that the living world has worth in itself, not only as human resource, and that the self, fully understood, extends into the web of relations that sustain it. What the school draws: a bridge language for partners who arrive through philosophy rather than faith.

The rights of nature. From Ecuador's constitution of 2008 to the settlements in Aotearoa, some courts and legislatures now treat the living world as a subject, not only an object. What the school draws: company. That the law of some states now says this is not evidence that the school's practice works.

X. Shapes That Recur

Read together, the traditions do not blur into sameness. Read by this school, for its own purposes, some shapes recur, and the school finds company in them:

- **Kinship, not wilderness.** Many of these worldviews refuse the cut between human and nature: relations, ancestors, Country, kami, creation — never "environment."
- **Reciprocity as law.** Ayni, toloka, the Honourable Harvest, ubuntu, the trust of the khalifa: taking obliges giving; care must circulate.
- **Gratitude as protocol.** Not a mood but a practice with a form — words before all else, grace, blessing, the morning circle.
- **Land as teacher.** Country, pattern languages, the ogham letters (a few of them named for trees), the tree read as roots, trunk, and canopy: the ground itself as curriculum.
- **Song and ceremony where words fail.** Grief, threshold, and joy carried in the body — vigil, joik, lament, dance — in many of the traditions above.
- **Long time.** The generations yet unborn, shmita cycles, groves kept for centuries: traditions that think in tree-time.
- **The accompanied journey.** Into the forest and back, with an adult alongside; the child comes home with something to share. An old shape of learning, found in many places.

That some such shapes recur from the Carpathians to the Baltic and across the Urals, from North America to Aotearoa, says something about people. It is not evidence for the school's philosophy, which the school holds as ground. It is good company.

XI. Synoptic View

The survey condensed to one view: each tradition, its core, and what the Forest School draws from it.

- **Hutsul and Ukrainian folk year.** Core: land lived with and respected; night vigils that kept no one alone beside the dead; the folk year kept within the Church. Drawn: for the elders to say. [for the elders]
- **The churches of this valley.** Core: creation as icon; blessing with water and branch; stillness of heart; care for the common home. Drawn: the families' feasts keep their place; Sundays with families; the priest welcome.
- **Baltic peoples.** Core: sacred groves and holy oaks; cosmology kept in the dainas; the Singing Revolution. Drawn: land-bond kept in song; singing together as survival and resistance.
- **Finnic north.** Core: the world sung; power through knowing origins; hiis groves; everyman's right. Drawn: knowing origins as relationship — the pattern card's question; belonging to land as right and care.
- **Norse world.** Core: Yggdrasil; landvættir, spirits of place; law spoken under open sky. Drawn: the tree as readable cosmos; arriving gently on any land; the circle outdoors.
- **Celts.** Core: nemeton groves; tree-named ogham letters; threshold festivals; long training in memory and verse. Drawn: an old precedent for teaching in the forest.
- **Mari (Mari El).** Core: küsoto sacred groves, prayers led by karts, practised openly today. Drawn: a grove-faith still kept in the open.
- **Udmurt (Udmurtia).** Core: kuala household shrines; lud groves. Drawn: the sacred at household scale.
- **Komi (Komi).** Core: the forest's own spirit; Perm animal-style bronzes; one of Europe's largest remaining virgin forests. Drawn: what reverence can keep.
- **Bashkirs (Bashkortostan).** Core: Ural-batyr, the water of life given to the land; wild-tree beekeeping. Drawn: a life given so that the land lives.
- **Khanty and Mansi (the Ob).** Core: the bear held in reverence; the bear festival's days and nights of sacred song and story. Drawn: a resemblance to the valley's vigils, not a shared origin.
- **Nenets (Yamal).** Core: herding families moving with the reindeer. Drawn: belonging carried in movement.
- **Evenki (the Siberian taiga).** Core: the source of the word "shaman". Drawn: nothing practised; the word not used.
- **Sakha; Altai, Tuva, Buryatia.** Core: Olonkho and Aal Luuk Mas; the eternal sky; oboo cairns; khoomei. Drawn: the cosmos read as a tree; reverence at travel's thresholds.
- **Haudenosaunee.** Core: the Thanksgiving Address; decisions weighed for the generations to come. Drawn: the Morning Circle knows the Address came first; planting for those not yet born.

- **Lakota.** Core: mitákuye oyás'į — all my relations. Drawn: the refusal of "wilderness"; the circle of care.
- **The Honourable Harvest (Kimmerer, Potawatomi).** Core: ask, take no more than half, use all, give back. Drawn: the ethic for every act of taking.
- **Aboriginal nations of Australia.** Core: Country as kin; songlines, held by their custodians. Drawn: respect, not method.
- **Māori (Aotearoa).** Core: whakapapa; kaitiakitanga; Te Urewera and the Whanganui River as legal persons, won in settlements. Drawn: guardianship as inherited duty, in the school's own words.
- **Andean peoples.** Core: Pachamama; ayni; sumak kawsay. Drawn: ayni beside the toloka as kin.
- **Sámi (Sápmi).** Core: the joik sings beings present. Drawn: song holding beings and places in presence.
- **Ubuntu; the Yoruba groves.** Core: a person is a person through other persons; Osun-Osogbo kept and restored. Drawn: care circulating; reverence that can keep a forest, and has not always been enough.
- **Shinto, and shinrin-yoku.** Core: kami in nature; forest bathing, named in 1982. Drawn: sensory immersion; silent walks.
- **Daoism.** Core: the living flow; wu-wei. Drawn: patient observation; the gardener's restraint.
- **Buddhism.** Core: bare attention; interbeing; impermanence. Drawn: attention in observation; letting go that feeds what comes.
- **Vedic and village India.** Core: sacred groves; ahimsa; Chipko. Drawn: care that became protection.
- **Judaism.** Core: bal tashchit; shmita; Tu B'Shvat. Drawn: rhythm as sacred law; an old protection of trees in war.
- **Islam.** Core: khalifa; mizan; planting as charity. Drawn: stewardship as trust.
- **Biophilia and eco-spirituality.** Core: an innate need for living systems. Drawn: hands in the soil as plain statement.
- **Deep ecology.** Core: the living world's own worth; the extended self. Drawn: a bridge language.
- **Rights of nature.** Core: the living world as legal subject, from Ecuador to Aotearoa. Drawn: company, not evidence.

XII. The Ethic of Borrowing

One rule governs the school's relationship to every tradition in this survey, and it is absolute:

The school honours by parallel, never by imitation. It does not perform the ceremonies of other peoples, does not adopt their sacred forms, and does not blend their practices into an unrooted mixture. It practises its own place's forms — Hutsul and Ukrainian, under the elders' authority — and recognises, with gratitude and by name, the traditions of the world in which it sees something of its own practice.

Where a teaching from elsewhere informs the school's understanding, it is credited to its people; where a practice belongs to a people, it stays with them. The survey above is a family album, not a catalogue of parts. The school's answer to the world's wisdom is not to borrow its songs but to sing, more faithfully, its own.

Source check and stress tests

Done 2026-09-27, by readers who had not seen the text being written.

Source check. Eighty-five factual claims tested against published sources: fifty-two confirmed, six wrong, eighteen overstated, five unverified. The wrong ones: the Hutsuls placed in the Finno-Ugric world; the Khanty and Mansi as the closest kin of Finnish and Estonian; the law on fruit trees dated three thousand years back; every ogham letter a tree; the Sámi as a reindeer people; the Honourable Harvest as a teaching of one nation. All are corrected above, with the overstated and unverified claims.

A reader from the named peoples. Found peoples used as proof of the school's worth; a Māori role-name and a kinship with songlines taken; the Evenki crossing half-practised; the Sámi reduced to herders; Turtle Island used for every nation. Found also that since November 2024, when Russia's Supreme Court listed 172 Indigenous organisations as terrorist, calling these peoples Ukraine's kin can be used against them. All corrected.

A parent, a priest, and an official in wartime Ukraine. Found no plain statement that nothing here is done with children; animism set as the ground with the Church as a later layer; the valley's churches placed seventh; the peoples of the Urals and Siberia read politically. Corrected: the note for families; the churches placed after the taproot; the Hutsul section rewritten for the elders; the section on the Urals and Siberia kept, by Michel Garand's decision, with each people named by its own land and spoken of only as it has shared its traditions.

An evidence reviewer. Found conviction presented as evidence throughout, against this survey's own opening note and the foundations paper, and the move that treats many traditions as one deep core, criticised by Steven Katz ("Language, Epistemology, and Mysticism", 1978). Corrected: the traditions are held as company, not evidence.

Sources for the corrections, searched 2026-09-27: Encyclopaedia Britannica and the Latvian dainas corpus; the UNESCO lists for Olonkho, the Virgin Komi Forests, and the Osun-Osogbo Sacred Grove; Radio Free Europe/Radio Liberty and Minority Rights Group on the Mari; Arctic Anthropology on the Khanty bear feast; the Glasgow ogham project; McManus, A Guide to Ogam; Caesar, Gallic War 6.14; the Milwaukee Public Museum on the Sámi; the Indigenous Values Initiative on the Thanksgiving Address; Kimmerer, Braiding Sweetgrass; the International Journal of the Commons on sacred groves;

the Te Urewera Act 2014 and Te Awa Tupua Act 2017; Laudato Si' 67; the Greek Orthodox Archdiocese of America on the Ecumenical Patriarch; Sahih al-Bukhari 2320; The Moscow Times, 22 November 2024; Katz, 1978.

Release record

- **Gate 1:** 2026-09-27, the household, recorded by Michel Garand — v0.7, revised after the source check and stress tests, for publication online as a working draft, open to co-creation and to change.
 - **Wartime review:** 2026-09-27, Michel Garand — names Soil and Peace and no place; the political reading of the section on the Urals and Siberia checked and decided; accepted.
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